

Changing dynamic levels

No matter how quiet or muted, or how dramatically loud and bombastic, composers want a performer to play, there is a dynamic term that they can use to indicate their wishes. Dynamics are fluid, and a crucial part of a performer's musical expressivity, so composers use a number of symbols to denote gradual or sudden changes in dynamic levels. This makes the music more interesting, and provides rewarding musical choices for the performer.

▽ Symbols

If a composer wants the performer to switch dynamic levels quickly and without warning, the word *subito*, or “suddenly” (abbreviated *sub.*) may be written next to the new dynamic marking.



Crescendo



Decrescendo



△ Crescendo on the staff

Often, composers want the musicians to gradually increase volume. This is called a crescendo, and is marked by a large sideways V under the notes.

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△ Decrescendo on the staff

A decrescendo is marked by a sideways V pointing the other way, indicating the composer's instruction for the volume to get gradually quieter during that portion.

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REAL WORLD

Dramatic dynamics

Composers play with dynamics and dynamic changes to creatively express different moods in music. In his 1893 Symphony No. 6, *Pathétique*, Pyotr Tchaikovsky called for the bassoon to play *pianissississississimo* (marked *ppppp*). The last movement of Ottorino Respighi's 1924 tone poem *Pines of Rome* is one of the longest, most gradual, and most dramatic crescendo in all of the orchestral repertoire.



The crescendo in *Pines of Rome* depicts a legion of **Roman soldiers** marching along the Via Appia, triumphantly **ascending** one of Rome's seven hills.